THE SYSTEM OF PROFESSIONS

An Essay on the Division of Expert Labor

Andrew Abbott

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Contents

Preface ix

1 Introduction 1

The Professions Literature 3
The Concept of Professionalization 9
Cases of Professional Development 20

I WORK, JURISDICTION, AND COMPETITION 33

2 Professional Work 35

Objective and Subjective 35
Diagnosis 40
Treatment 40
Inference 48
Academic Knowledge 52

3 The Claim of Jurisdiction 59

Audiences 59
Settlements 69
Internal Structure 79

4 The System of Professions 86

The Implications of Exclusion: A System of Professions 86
Sources of System Disturbances 91
The Mechanisms of Jurisdiction Shift: Abstraction 98
Conclusion 111

II THE SYSTEM'S ENVIRONMENT 115

5 Internal Differentiation and the Problem of Power 117

Internal Stratification 118
Client Differentiation 122
Workplace, Workplace Structure, and Internal Divisions of Labor 125
Career Patterns 129
Power 134

6 The Social Environment of Professional Development 143

Forces Opening and Closing Jurisdictions 144
The Internal Organization of Professional Work 150
Changing Audiences for Jurisdictional Claims 157
Co-optable Powers, Oligarchy, and the New Class 167

7 The Cultural Environment of Professional Development 177

Changes in the Organization of Knowledge 177
New Forms of Legitimacy 184
The Rise of Universities 195

III THREE CASE STUDIES 213

8 The Information Professions 215

The Qualitative Task Area 217
The Quantitative Task Area 226
The Combined Jurisdiction 239

9 Lawyers and Their Competitors 247

Potential Jurisdictional Conflicts of the Legal Profession 248
Complaints about Unqualified Practice and Other Invasions 254
Conclusions 275

10 The Construction of the Personal Problems Jurisdiction 280

The Status of Personal Problems, 1850–75 281

The First Response to "American Nervousness" 285
The Psychiatric Revolution 294
The Rise of Psychotherapy 300
Conclusion: The Clergy Surrender 308

11 Conclusion 315
The System of Professions 315
History 319
Theory and the Professions 323

Notes 327

References 389

Index 423

Preface

On a brave spring morning in 1973, I sat with two psychiatrists in the office of John R. Collier, superintendent of Illinois's Manteno State Hospital. After a year observing the use of psychiatric knowledge in an outpatient clinic, I was now ready to analyze the stranger world of the mental hospital. Friends had introduced me to David Turner and David Klass, consultant specialists at Manteno, the great chronic hospital that anchored the Illinois state mental health system. The place overwhelmed me. Dozens of ward buildings covered a square mile of prairie. So regular was their formation that when we had passed beside the northernmost ward on the way to the administration building, I had seen through its porch arches the concentric outlines of equivalent arches on ward after ward to the very end of the hospital. While Collier read my little letter of intent, I looked out at the briskly snapping state flag and thought of Foucault finding in those arches the triumph of regularity and order. Turner and Klass joked quietly. Finally, Collier glanced up. "I don't see why you need to go on the wards to study psychiatric knowledge," he grinned. "All the psychiatric knowledge in this hospital's sitting right here in this room."

I was later to see what Collier had meant. To care for its 3,500 patients, Manteno employed only one board-certified psychiatrist and indeed only three or four licensed physicians. Most medical care was performed by unlicensed foreign doctors, who were at that very moment dreading the brand-new Federal Licensing Examination. Turner and Klass, by contrast, had both been chief residents at the University of Chicago; in an official sense, they and Anne-Marie Rohan, the one board-certified staff member, did indeed possess all the psychiatric knowledge in the hospital.

"In an official sense. . . ." What is it to possess and control expertise? After five years at Manteno, I had spent more time with mental patients, seen more of their activities, and endured more of their jokes than most psychiatrists do in a lifetime. I had lost pool matches to manic-depressives and poker games to schizophrenics. I had dodged clutching fingers that had killed four less-agile people. I had conversed with an elderly man who lived what Wittgenstein wrote. I had helped administer several tons of thorazine, mellaril, and their cousins, and the pounds of cogentin and artane to control their side effects. Yet, "in an official sense," five years at Manteno did not make me an expert on the insane.

They did, however, make me wonder why I was not. I went on to write a thesis on psychiatry as a profession and then began to consider the general issue of how modern societies institutionalize expertise. I knew that the common form of that institutionalization was professionalism. Many writers had studied professionalism, but few, I felt, studied the basic conditions and contexts of the control of work. Most studied the organization and affiliation of practitioners, and, for most, professionalism was either a phenomenon happening to individual professions or a grand sea change in the occupational system generally. There was in this work little sense of the squabbles between the Manteno psychologists and social workers over who could interpret diagnostic tests, of the war between our attorneys and our doctors over the patients who were incompetent to stand trial, of the vast distance between Klass, Turner, and Rohan on the one hand and the foreign ward doctors on the other. Of course, all of these problems had been studied individually. But with the exception of some work by Everett Hughes's students—particularly Eliot Freidson, Rue Bucher, and Anselm Strauss—there was no theory about them. There was certainly no attempt to see these interprofessional battles as central aspects of professionalism, rather than as isolated movements and pathologies.

In typical Chicago fashion, then, this book grew out of my experiences as a participant observer. That the book's evidence is mostly historical should not obscure its fieldwork origins. My Manteno years, and the clinic year before them, forced me towards a theory that could reconcile the historical continuity of professional appearances with the day-to-day discontinuities of professional reality. I experienced this disjunction quite personally. Manteno psychologists eagerly participated in their profession's war with psychiatry, actively lobbying for third-party payment. Yet their everyday professional world was so insecure that they protested in vain when administrators placed my uncertified self into the civil service "psychologist" classification.

Yet these local vicissitudes reflect larger reality, and a serious theory of professional development must embrace and explain this larger reality as well. Manteno's professionals struggled within a historical environment of peculiar intensity. Deinstitutionalization of mental patients was in full swing, destroying professionals' jobs as it fulfilled their ideologies. Biological psychiatry was rapidly recouping the doctors' position against the counseling professions, although token economies were making a substantial counterattack. Within the counseling area itself, psychoanalysis was at last losing its monopolistic dominance, and the flood tide of nonmedical psychotherapy beginning to flow. It was a time of great hope and change.

Yet the prevailing feeling of the hospital was of decline. Around us stood mute witnesses to the death of the asylum. When I stayed at the hospital on summer evenings I would walk at sunset past rank on rank of empty wards, past swings and seesaws unused for decades. The thousand-acre hospital farms had been rented to sod and corn farmers. The great southern lawn had become a public golf course. The diesel switching engine stood idle by the power plant, behind the empty kitchens that had once fed ten thousand persons a day. Beyond the power plant, the railroad siding snaked two weedy miles towards the Illinois Central tracks, passing an orchard where a few hardy trees still produced worm-eaten fruit. On such an evening, the whole history of the asylum hospital gleamed on the signs naming the wards—the idealistic founders Pinel and Dix, the famous Europeans Kraepelin, Freud, and Adler, the great Americans Rush, Meyer, and Mitchell. There were buildings, too, for other professions important to the asylum hospital—Barton and Nightingale for the nurses, Addams and Wines for the social workers, James for the psychologists. If I have captured in this book a sense of professions' transiency, it owes much to this experience of the dying hospital.

This book, then, aims to show the professions growing, splitting, joining, adapting, dying. The objects of its analysis include a wide variety of professions in the United States, England, and, to some extent, France and the other nations of continental Europe. I have been catholic in my tastes, trying to offset the customary reliance on American law and medicine. (I have generally avoided writing about academic professions, hoping to escape charges of navel gazing from nonacademic readers and the sense of we-know-it-all-already among academics.) The breadth of examples requires the usual disclaimer a synthetic writer makes to area specialists. Few of these analyses other than those in my own primary research areas will seem sophisticated to specialists on individual professions. I have done my best in unfamiliar territo-

ries, but doubtless many minor errors remain. On the other hand, that I write such a book testifies to my belief that synthesis will prove more worthwhile than further area work. Readers can judge for themselves whether that belief is correct.

Since the roots of the book lie in my personal experiences and observations, my first debts are to those who got me into the field; to Morris Janowitz, who pushed me into field study in my first year at Chicago; to Jarl Dyrud and Dave Klass, who got me into Manteno; to Klass and Jon Steinmetz, who managed to support me there for five years. Like all field observers, I have great debts to my subjects. Unlike most observers, however, I have the pleasure, afforded by ten years' time and a book using little of their evidence directly, of thanking the most important of them by name. Eberhard Uhlenhuth and his clinic staff, particularly Rose West, Mark Moulthrop, Dave Turner, Polly Everett, Zanvel Klein, and Jeff Teich, helped me immensely. The Chicago psychiatric residents of the 1972–1974 classes put up with numerous bumblings, for the most part with unfailing good humor.

At Manteno my debts are more extensive, because my stay was longer and my participation more complete. For official authorizations and support I must particularly thank Jack Collier and his successor Ella Curry. For varying degrees of forbearance and helpfulness I must thank the professional staffs, particularly Solomon Noguera and Luis Palacios among the doctors, Henry Lin among psychologists, Nora Brashear and Bonnie Hellyer among social workers. Among ward people I owe great debts especially to Janet Tetrault, Penny Kneissler, Doug Baldridge, Raymond Marshall, Dennis Hopkins, Marge Curry, and Harold Spearin. Among the nonprofessional staff, Arvada Ruder, Doris White, and Charlotte Morgan were helpful and supportive, as were John Crayton and Mike Strizich among the Chicago-based consultants. Finally, I must thank friends whose personal support got me through Manteno's deadlier moments—Dave Rudolf, Margaret Kasper, Jon Steinmetz, and, *dulcissima*, Cindi Clyden.

Over the years, a number of friends in diverse professions have talked intimately about their work. For this I must thank in particular Scott Thatcher, Richard Kalb, and James Gill, lawyer, architect, and priest. I have learned much about engineering from talks with my father. My mother taught me about librarianship by making me work in various libraries she ran, and I have indulged my enduring interest in libraries with indexing theorist Jim Anderson. My firsthand knowledge of the military I owe to Richard Nixon.

Beyond these general debts, I have some more specific debts for ideas in the book. The notion that diagnosis and treatment are general

modes of knowledge came from Donald Levine, and the vacancy metaphor that underlies chapter 4 from Harrison White. In most of the book I have softened the vacancy metaphor into a more ecological one so that the relative positions of professions might seem somewhat less exclusive. Although ecology is a fashionable metaphor in sociology today, the book's ecological flavor comes directly from Park, Burgess, Zorbaugh, and others of the old Chicago School. Reading this work in the early 1970s, I came to see social structures as fluctuating and geographic, conceptions that strongly underlie this book. They underlie as well the Chicago writers on occupations and professions, and the book thus lies very much in the Everett Hughes tradition. The book's comparative emphasis has diverse sources. Although I originally designed my dissertation study of American psychiatrists without much comparative knowledge, Joseph Ben-David shamed me into studying other professions and other countries. The comparative emphasis was reinforced when I was able to attend two years of sessions on the history of professions at Princeton's Davis Center. Although the Princeton historians had little respect for sociologists, they did examine an immense amount of information about various professions, and I would not have dared so broad a book without the exposure I acquired there.

Like any synthetic scholar, I owe much to past sociological and historical work. On the sociological side, Joseph Ben-David, Magali Larson, Eliot Freidson, and Terence Johnson have been particularly important theoretical sources, as have the earlier synthetic books of Geoffrey Millerson, W. J. Reader, and A. M. Carr-Saunders and P. A. Wilson. A number of sociological colleagues have talked professions with me for years, and I must thank them, particularly Terence Halliday and Michael Powell, for their insights and criticism. To the historians I owe a still greater debt, for theirs is the data that undergirds the book. Although sources are of course listed where relevant, I must thank here those historians who have personally shaped my ideas: Gerald Geison, Steve Botein, Nancy Tomes, Janet Tighe, Gerald Grob, Paul Miranti, and Robert Kohler.

A number of people have read the book manuscript, or pieces of it. Terry Halliday, Mark Granovetter, Doug Nelson, Eliot Freidson, Harrison White, and Susan Gal gave me very helpful, although often contradictory, comments. Two research assistants, Bruce Carruthers and Margaret Antinori, helped with material appearing in chapters 1 and 8. Ed Laumann was helpful at publication time. Financial support came in small amounts from faculty grants at Rutgers, and in large ones from my wife's real world salary from Bell Laboratories. Portions of the manuscript have appeared before, and I must thank the relevant jour-

nals for permission to reprint; chapter 9 appeared virtually in its entirety in the *American Bar Foundation Research Journal* and portions of chapter 10 in *Sociological Analysis*. I must also thank the Harvard University Department of Sociology, whose invitation in 1982 provoked my first formal discussion of the central argument of the book.

A first book is the proper occasion for acknowledging help of years ago that led, in its circuitous way, to this present. I thank, then, my parents, James and Rita Abbott, for fostering me in the life of the mind and some teachers who furthered that endeavor: Seaver Gilcreast, Sr., Robert Shields, George Best, Simeon Hyde, Dudley Fitts, R. H. Goodyear, J. P. Russo. I thank also those who exemplified for me what that life could be: Alston Chase, Roger Revelle, Morris Janowitz.

Lastly, I thank those who made life fun while I wrote this book. Among my present and former colleagues at Rutgers, Stan DeViney, Andy Szasz, Randy Smith, Rob Parker, and Judy Gerson have criticized, cheered, and supported, as did that anthropologist who is still my closest friend thirty years after we were third grade sweethearts.

Finally, by her support, threat, cajolery, and exhortation, Sue Schlough probably has as much to do with the appearance of this manuscript as I do. She did not read it, or type it, or prepare the index. But she interrupted her plane trips and experiments to do much more than her share of the dishwashing and cleaning (I think I've held up my end of the ironing and cooking). As any two-career couple knows, that's a big deal. We've had a great time while this book was being written, and that's an even bigger deal. Thanks.

A.M.D.G.

Phillipsburg, New Jersey
14 July 1987

Note for the reader: This is a long book, with long and often involved arguments. To make the argument followable, I have suppressed all citation in text. This makes the scholarly machinery harder to follow—something I resent when *I* read—but it makes the book much more readable. I apologize to those who want to check everything as they go along. James Anderson kindly assisted me with the index. Its unfortunate brevity was dictated by considerations of space.

1 Introduction

The professions dominate our world. They heal our bodies, measure our profits, save our souls. Yet we are deeply ambivalent about them. For some, the rise of professions is a story of knowledge in triumphant practice. It is the story of Pasteur and Osler and Schweitzer, a thread that ties the lawyer in a country village to the justice on the Supreme Court bench. For others it is a sadder chronicle of monopoly and malfeasance, of unequal justice administered by servants of power, of Rockefeller medicine men.[1] Beneath the impassioned contradictions of these interpretations lie some common assumptions. Most authors study professions one at a time. Most assume that professions grow through a series of stages called professionalization. Most talk less about what professions do than about how they are organized to do it.

These assumptions seem to emerge from our central questions about professions. Why should there be occupational groups controlling the acquisition and application of various kinds of knowledge? Where and why did groups like medicine and law achieve their power? Will professionalism spread throughout the occupational world? To answer such puzzling questions, it seemed necessary to adopt simplifying assumptions. The complexities of the individual professions forced case by case study. The fact that professions like medicine and architecture seemed more similar in organizational pattern than in actual work made organizational pattern the focus of analysis. The focus on pattern implied in turn a search for its origins and led to the idea of a common process of development, the idea of professionalization. But professionalization was at best a misleading concept, for it involved more the forms than the contents of professional life. It ignored who was doing what to whom and how, concentrating instead on associ-

ation, licensure, ethics code. In fact, not only did it miss the contents of professional activity, but also the larger situation in which that activity occurs.

By focusing on parallels in organizational development, students of the professions lost sight of a fundamental fact of professional life—interprofessional competition. Control of knowledge and its application means dominating outsiders who attack that control. Control without competition is trivial. Study of organizational forms can indeed show how certain occupations control their knowledge and its application. But it cannot tell why those forms emerge when they do or why they sometimes succeed and sometimes fail. Only the study of competition can accomplish that.

The professions, that is, make up an interdependent system. In this system, each profession has its activities under various kinds of jurisdiction. Sometimes it has full control, sometimes control subordinate to another group. Jurisdictional boundaries are perpetually in dispute, both in local practice and in national claims. It is the history of jurisdictional disputes that is the real, the determining history of the professions. Jurisdictional claims furnish the impetus and the pattern to organizational developments. Thus an effective historical sociology of professions must begin with case studies of jurisdictions and jurisdiction disputes. It must then place these disputes in a larger context, considering the system of professions as a whole. It must study such evolving systems in several countries to assess exogenous factors shaping systems of professions. Only from such portraits can one derive an effective model for understanding and predicting professional development in modern societies generally.[2]

The movement from an individualistic to a systematic view of professions organizes this book. I begin by evaluating the idea of professionalization and move on to theorize the systematic relations of professions. I then analyze external forces bearing on the system and close by discussing three important examples of contested jurisdictions. Throughout, I addresss the familiar questions about professions. How do professions develop? How do they relate to one another? What determines the kind of work they do?

But this summary slights a methodological theme that accompanies the substantive one as harmony does a melody. My substantive questions all involve generalizing about stories, such as stories of professionalization. My methodological concern is with how this generalization takes place. Traditional theories of professionalization argue that professions follow a certain sequence of development. This "careers" model is one way to generalize about sequences of social events. My

theoretical scheme, particularly in Chapter 4, illustrates a different way of generalizing about sequences, one that makes them interdependent. Since jurisdiction is the defining relation in professional life, the sequences that I generalize are sequences of jurisdictional control, describing who had control of what, when, and how. Professions develop when jurisdictions become vacant, which may happen because they are newly created or because an earlier tenant has left them altogether or lost its firm grip on them. If an already existing profession takes over a vacant jurisdiction, it may in turn vacate another of its jurisdictions or retain merely supervisory control of it. Thus events propagate backwards in some sense, with jurisdictional vacancies, rather than the professions themselves, having much of the intiative. This simple system model shows how a set of historical stories can be analyzed without assuming a common career pattern, as in the concept of professionalization.[3]

Throughout the book, then, run two levels of analysis. Substantively, the book answers some questions about the evolution of professions. Methodologically, it considers the difficulties of generalizing about sequences of events and proposes a new way to address them. It both does historical sociology and asks how historical sociology ought to be done.

The Professions Literature

Although the professions derive from medieval or in some cases ancient origins, the first systematic attempts to study them came in this century. In part this reflected the rise of the social sciences, but it reflected more importantly a great change in the professions themselves. The nineteenth century saw the first development of professions as we know them today. In England the merging of apothecaries with surgeons and physicians, the rise of the lower branch of the legal profession, and the appearance of the surveyors, architects, and accountants signaled the change. In America the triumphs of regular medicine over its various sects, the growth of the university professional schools, and the host of would-be professions all testified to the new form of occupation.[4]

The nineteenth century professions were important but peculiar social creatures. With the exception of accounting, they stood outside the new commercial and industrial heart of society. They were organized in a collegial manner that was distinctly anachronistic. On the Continent, to be sure, the professions were more hierarchical. But this hierarchy came not from the new capitalist forms of organization, but

rather from the Old Regime, from which it acquired a civil servant quality quite peculiar in the modern occupational world. The professions, and in particular the Anglo-American variety, were therefore a great puzzle for social theorists. Weber spent many embarrassed pages confronting the wanton irrationality of the English Bar. Durkheim simply ignored the Anglo-American professions altogether and looked to more familiar French occupations for his neocorporatist future.[5]

It was the English themselves who perforce first analyzed these unusual occupations. Carr-Saunders and Wilson's *The Professions*, published in 1934, was the first such attempt.[6] The book gave historical background on every group that could then be considered a profession in England. Its theoretical discussion systematized a view of professions that had by then come to dominate the writings both of the professions themselves and of the social scientists examining them. Professions were organized bodies of experts who applied esoteric knowledge to particular cases. They had elaborate systems of instruction and training, together with entry by examination and other formal prerequisites. They normally possessed and enforced a code of ethics or behavior. This list of properties became the core of later definitions.

The Carr-Saunders and Wilson volume epitomized two methodologies characteristic of writing on professions, combining naturalism and typology. Early articles on the professions would summarize the life history of their particular case, review the then-current essential traits of a true profession, and decide whether social work or nursing or whatever really was a profession. Work in this genre rapidly built the stock of case studies, fitting each case into the procrustean bed of essential traits. But that bed was so often refinished as it passed from hand to hand that the case studies were never very comparable. By 1964, when Geoffrey Millerson attempted a new general analysis of professions, he had to treat earlier work as merely advisory and build on new data in a new framework.[7] Millerson recognized that trait-based definitions had often reflected political concerns. If one disliked social work, one easily found some trait excluding social work from the prestigious category of "professions." He himself avoided this by identifying only very general traits of professionalism (e.g., organization, education, ethics) and then permitting wide variation within them.

Other authors confronted this empirical diversity more directly. An early and parsimonious answer came from the theorists of professionalization. The diversity of the would-be professions arose because professional status was an end state that few had yet achieved. Diversity would disappear with time, as groups gradually acquired all the marks of true professions. The concept of professionalization thus consum-

mated the marriage of naturalism and typology. Professionalization was a natural process, as in the case study literature, but that process entailed a series of types. In 1964 Harold Wilensky published an article that demonstrated such a regular sequence in the American professions. Professionalization seemed an established fact. The new conceptualization meant in turn a new theoretical question. Why did professionalization follow the sequence it did?

But just as professionalization became an established concept, the study of professions was suddenly reshaped by the new political climate of the 1960s. Early work on professionalization had rested on the functional assumptions characteristic of postwar sociology. It attributed the collegial organization of professions to their position as experts. The "asymmetry of expertise" required the client to trust the professional and the professional to respect both client and colleagues. These relations were guaranteed by various institutional forms—associations, licensure, ethics codes. But theorists rejecting functional assumptions disputed the whole picture. In a lucid analysis of professionalism as a form of control, Johnson argued that the professions did not serve disembodied social needs but rather imposed both definitions of needs and manner of service on atomized consumers. Writing on American medicine, Eliot Freidson argued that dominance and autonomy, not collegiality and trust, were the hallmarks of true professionalism. Another student of medicine, Jeffrey Berlant, attributed the structures of professionalism directly to the goals of economic monopoly. Berlant's work was the more striking in that the feature of professionalism whose monopolistic function he most carefully analyzed was ethics codes, whose altruistic nature had been assumed by earlier workers.[8]

By seeing monopoly rather than control of asymmetric relationships, the new theorists moved the focus of debate from the forms of professionalization to its functions. For the new theorists, the regularity of professionalization was not the visible regularity of school, then association, then ethics code, but rather the hidden one of successive functions for these professional forms. Ethics codes came late in professionalization not because they were a culmination of natural growth, but because they served the function of excluding outsiders, a function that became important only after the professional community had been generated and consolidated. Since ethics codes did not serve these earlier functions, they came late.

The new power literature thus unmasked earlier work as ideological. This unmasking reached its final form in Magali Larson's *The Rise of Professionalism* (1977). Here professions were explicitly market or-

ganizations attempting the intellectual and organizational domination of areas of social concern. Yet even while it reversed the traditional images of profession and professional, Larson's book drew on themes and assumptions standard throughout the Anglo-American study of professions. The old model was accepted for new reasons. Since she cast professions as market dominating organizations, Larson ruled out the professions of the Continent, where expertise was never formalized independent of the state. Like her predecessors in the power tradition, she explicitly excluded the organization-based professions—armed and civil service and clergy—that continue in the Anglo-American world the institutional forms of the Continent. Through her focus on dominance she ignored professions like nursing that had accepted subordination. The exclusions should come as no surprise. By accepting professionalization as the thing to be explained, the new power theorists accepted the assumptions behind the concept. These included not only the idea of a fixed sequence of events or functions, but also assumptions about the best examples of professionalism (American medicine and law), about its essential qualities, and about the character of the interprofessional world.

The split between the functionalists and the monopolists was thus not total. It was also not one-dimensional. First, the two groups emphasized different consequences of professionalism. Berlant and Larson were interested in the consequences of medical professionalism not for health, but rather for the status and power of the medical profession. These were external, social consequences that derived from professional status or activity; sickness was of little interest. Other writers emphasized internal consequences of professionalism, consequences affecting the area of professional work itself—healing, auditing, and so on. To Parsons, for example, the impact of professionalism on sick individuals was of central importance. Yet it was also central for Freidson, whose critical stance otherwise identifies him with Larson and Berlant. This contrast between Parsons and Freidson indicates the other dimension of the split, which concerns the locus of analysis; like Larson but unlike Parsons, Freidson aimed his analysis at the social level. He asked how the overall social handling of illness was affected by the existence and nature of professional groups. Similarly, Larson's concern with the external consequences of professionalism extended to the profession as a whole. She asked what professions got out of professionalism and how. Parsons and other functionalists, while concerned, like Freidson, with internal consequences, saw them at the individual level. How, they asked, does a social relation between client and professional have to be structured for healing (or some other individual professional act) to occur?

Of course, the crossing of these two dichotomies implies a fourth approach, one examining external consequences, as do Larson and Berlant, but at the level of individuals. This view has been argued at length by Joseph Ben-David and Burton Bledstein. Both emphasize the function of professionalism in protecting certain individuals—the professionals themselves—from the structured, rigid employment that emerged with nineteenth century capitalism. Beyond this independence, they both argued, professionalism also provided both an ideal metaphor for vertical mobility and the means with which to attempt it. This argument defines the chief implications of professionalism as its external consequences (status, money, power), but at the individual level. Professionalism was a matter of individual choices and corporate action taken to protect or extend them.[9]

The literature on professions has thus gradually moved from naturalism to theory. It began with case studies and typologies. The internal contradictions of these studies led ultimately to the idea of professionalization, in which a developmental typology generated the natural histories, producing an apparent variety of professions. For the process of professionalization there then emerged a variety of theoretical interpretations. For some, professionalism was a means to control a difficult social relation; for others, a species of corporate extortion. For still others its importance lay in building individual achievement channels, while a fourth group emphasized how it helped or hindered general social functions like health and justice.

Despite their substantive differences, authors of these theories took a surprisingly consistent view of what professions were and what about them must be explained. Certainly all agreed that a profession was an occupational group with some special skill. Usually this was an abstract skill, one that required extensive training. It was not applied in a purely routine fashion, but required revised application case by case. In addition, professions were more or less exclusive.

This consensus seems surprising in light of the squabbles characteristic of the period of naturalistic studies. For many years the definitional question was the focal issue of studies of professions, obscuring the substantive questions that made professions interesting in the first place.[10] But of course the surprising consensus of theoretical writers reflected the place of definition in theoretical work, where it is a means to substantive ends. The confusion over definitions arose mainly in writing that lacked theoretical intent. There, definitions were judged by their ability to regenerate common opinions. Since those opinions were organized around the familiar examples of American law and medicine, definitions excluded things that didn't look like law and medicine, such as automobile repair, and included things that did, like

accounting and perhaps social work. There were and are fundamental difficulties with this test-by-example. First, American law and medicine do not in fact look like our images of them. Only half of each is self-employed. The vast majority of work in both is utterly routine. A surprising number of professionals, even in these fields, will be in another occupational classification in twenty years.[11] Second, many groups that obviously *are* professions do not look like American medicine and law at all. English barristers do not necessarily train in university but rather by apprenticeship and eating dinners "in hall." American clergy do not generally have ethics codes nor, until recently, associations independent of their ecclesiastical structure. Yet both groups are unmistakably professions. The underlying problem is that for many writers, calling something a profession makes it one. People don't want to call automobile repair a profession because they don't want to accord it that dignity. This unwillingness probably has less to do with the actual characteristics of automobile repair as an intellectual discipline—which are conceptually quite close to those of medicine—than it does with the status of the work and of those who do it. When definitions aim to distinguish groups according to such an external agenda, they are disputed. When used to answer theoretical questions, they are not.

Definitions, then, must follow from theoretical questions. The theory I sketched in the opening paragraphs implies the very loose definition that professions are exclusive occupational groups applying somewhat abstract knowledge to particular cases. It is important to show why this definition is chosen here. In doing so, I can further outline my fundamental theory.

My underlying questions concern the evolution and interrelations of professions, and, more generally, the ways occupational groups control knowledge and skill. I have already argued that the evolution of professions in fact results from their interrelations. These interrelations are in turn determined by the way these groups control their knowledge and skill. There are two rather different ways of accomplishing this control. One emphasizes technique per se, and occupations using it are commonly called crafts. To control such an occupation, a group directly controls its technique. The other form of control involves abstract knowledge. Here, practical skill grows out of an abstract system of knowledge, and control of the occupation lies in control of the abstractions that generate the practical techniques. The techniques themselves may in fact be delegated to other workers. For me this characteristic of abstraction is the one that best identifies the professions. For abstraction is the quality that sets interprofessional

competition apart from competition among occupations in general. Any occupation can obtain licensure (e.g., beauticians) or develop an ethics code (e.g., real estate). But only a knowledge system governed by abstractions can redefine its problems and tasks, defend them from interlopers, and seize new problems—as medicine has recently seized alcoholism, mental illness, hyperactivity in children, obesity, and numerous other things. Abstraction enables survival in the competitive system of professions. If auto mechanics had that kind of abstraction, if they "contained" the relevant sections of what is presently the engineering profession, and had considered taking over all repair of internal combustion engines on abstract grounds, they would, for my purposes, be a profession.

My central questions and my framework thus determine my definition of profession. As we have just seen, they determine first its emphasis on the knowledge system and its degree of abstraction, since these are the ultimate currency of competition between professions. But they also determine its relativity, since the degree of abstraction necessary for survival varies with time and place in the system of professions. As social work and nursing have become collegiate professions, medicine has become postgraduate. How abstract is abstract enough to be professional? The answer depends on time and place. What matters is abstraction effective enough to compete in a particular historical and social context, not abstraction relative to some supposed absolute standard. I am interested not merely in the living, dominant professions like medicine and law, but also in the the moribund groups like mediums, railway surgeons, and electrotherapists. A definition too specific would exclude them from view. Yet they too have made their mark on the system of professions we see today.[12]

The Concept of Professionalization

Having settled the definitional issue, at least temporarily, we may move on to examine past theories of professional development more closely. Probably the most common theme of past work is that professions tend to develop in a common pattern, called professionalization. Is there, in fact, a common story of how professions develop? To answer this question, we must first answer the preliminary one of what we mean by "common story." This question is quite complex. There have been many theories of professionalization, and they differ along two distinctly different dimensions—the formal and the substantive.

Let us consider formal differences among theories of professionalization by studying some versions of the professionalization story. In

the 1964 article mentioned earlier, Harold Wilensky discussed what he called "the professionalization of everyone." Wilensky looked at the dates of "first events" in various American professions—first training school, first university school, first local association, first national association, first state licensing law, and first code of ethics. He found by inspection that the events usually fell in the order just listed. Reflecting on that order, he then made up a story to account for it. I shall paraphrase it as follows:

> Professions begin when people "start doing full time the thing that needs doing." But then the issue of training arises, pushed by recruits or clients. Schools are created. The new schools, if not begun within universities, immediately seek affiliation with them. Inevitably, there then develop higher standards, longer training, earlier commitment to the profession, and a group of full time teachers. Then the teaching professionals, along with their first graduates, combine to promote and create a professional association. The more active professional life enabled by this association leads to self-reflection, to possible change of name, and to an explicit attempt to separate competent from incompetent. Reflection about central tasks leads the profession to delegate routine work to paraprofessionals. At the same time the attempt to separate competent from incompetent leads to internal conflict between the officially trained younger generation and their on-the-job-trained elders, as well as to increasingly violent confrontations with outsiders. This period also contains efforts to secure state protection, although this does not always occur and is not peculiar to professions in any case. Finally, the rules that these events have generated, rules eliminating internal competition and charlatanry and establishing client protection, coalesce in a formal ethics code.[13]

Wilensky's story consists of a series of narrative steps, each of which moves from situation to event to situation. What propels these steps? Here Wilensky is less clear. He tells who pushes for schools, but not why. Presumably he uses some commonsense theory like "people who are doing something full time want to do it well," or "see a need to do it well," or "begin to know what it is to do it well." Note that the causal models underlying the various links in this story draw on different general views of why things happen in social life. Schools arise functionally; they fill a need. Delegation of tasks, by contrast, arises in a historicist manner (success confers the power to delegate, which further enhances success), while ethics codes simply coalesce inevitably.

Who is the subject of this story? This, too, is problematic. Ethics codes happen to the profession as a whole. Yet at the beginning of Wilensky's story, the profession as a whole did not really exist. The initial subjects are "those who do full time the thing that needs doing." Through the story the profession gradually emerges as the new central

subject of the narrative, although often the agents or occasions of change come from subgroups. At one level this seems obvious enough. One central process of professionalization is coalescence into a group. But there is an essential difference between demonstrating emergence as a process in the social world and presupposing it by means of a narrative structure. It is the latter that Wilensky has done; at least some of the "full-time doers" have in fact become defined as charlatans by the latter stages of the story.

Although Wilensky theorized a general process of professionalization, he saw variety in the actual sequences and advanced special explanations of deviations from his overall story. Theodore Caplow, in contrast, saw a more strictly universal story. We can paraphrase it as follows:

> Professions begin with the establishment of professional associations that have explicit membership rules to exclude the unqualified. Second, they change their names, in order to lose their past, to assert their monopoly, and, most importantly, to give themselves a label capable of legislative restriction. Third, they set up a code of ethics to assert their social utility, to further regulate the incompetent, and to reduce internal competition. Fourth, they agitate politically to obtain legal recognition, aiming at first to limit the professional title and later to criminalize unlicensed work in their jurisdiction. (The growth of schooling Caplow sees as concurrent with this political activity, as he does the establishment of confidentiality rights and effective relations with outsiders.)[14]

Caplow's story differs from Wilensky's not only in chronology but in narrative structure as well. For one thing, it has a uniform central subject. The profession appears at the beginning of the story and undertakes all the activity in it. For another, all links of the story are functional. In fact, there is a sequence of functions. Exclusion is included in all four links, assertion of jurisdiction in the last three, internal control in the last two, and external relations only in the last. This sequence of functions is triggered by the need for professionalization, which Caplow derives from larger social forces in a separate argument. Yet despite these differences, Caplow's story shares with Wilensky's the assertion that there are clear sequences of professionalization.

This clear succession disappears in professionalization as described in English sources. Geoffrey Millerson's explicit denial shows the very different approach he takes to narrating professionalization.

> Clearly all Qualifying Associations did not begin as straightforward attempts to gain professional status. Immediate causes, so far as they can be traced, reveal a variety of reasons for establishing an association; to co-ordinate the activities of workers within an occupation; to offer facilities not otherwise available; to

provide for new technological development. Subsequently these associations introduced examinations and sought to improve members' status.

Foundation of associations often failed to follow a simple chain of events: technological advance and/or commercial advancement—demand for personnel—organization of personnel. More important, such a notion ignores the variable time-lag between first appearance of personnel and ultimate organization. Sometimes formation anticipated an expanding demand in an occupational area, the establishment of specialists and consequent need for 'qualified people'. Occasionally further development of association justified the founders' foresight. At times, slow development of the association suggested the evident inability of the association to satisfy requirements for qualified personnel, or a false anticipation of need for organization.[15]

Millerson here insists on a variety of possibilities. The organization may anticipate, it may follow a given demand; it may be too much too soon, it may be too little too late. That is, Millerson believes that the link between full-time work (i.e., demand) and association may be emplotted in a variety of ways. In an earlier discussion, after illustrating the impossibility of a single plot, he lists the possible models (all functional) for the link leading to a successful qualifying association—to achieve or consolidate status or prestige, to break away or react to an existing association, to coordinate existing practitioners, and to respond to utterly new occupational possibilities.

This diversity in part reflects the complexity of the British professions. But it also reflects several decisions Millerson has made about how to tell his story. First, he does not accept the implicit self-interest model that unifies the professionalization narratives of Wilensky and Caplow. Self-interest is but one among a number of theoretically possible motives for action. Second, he uses a different strategy to assemble his data. Wilensky looked at a set of first facts across professions and made up a story to fit them. Caplow's model is clearly based on much the same process, using the stories of journalists, undertakers, junk dealers, and laboratory technicians. Millerson, on the contrary, begins not with the bare details of first facts, but with individual narratives, profession by profession, complete with standard historical accounts of motivation. He looks at all his organizational histories and sees four or five reasons why organizations were set up. Since he has no fundamental model of self-interest to tie all these reasons together, he leaves them as independent versions of the link from demand to organization. He employs a similar strategy in studying the link between schools and examinations.

Millerson's analysis also reminds us of the complexity involved in ordered social processes. Sometimes we see the present as independ-

ent of the past, a position Millerson follows with regard to professional ethics. Sometimes we see the present as uniquely determined by the past; a profession has only one place to go next from where it is now, only one career to follow. This career model is the one chosen by Caplow and to a lesser extent by Wilensky. Millerson, on the other hand, generally uses the less-restrictive idea of contingent development. Even though the past shapes the future, there are several outcomes for any professional present. The next event after professional association may be licensing, examinations, or an ethics code. The important questions are which one and why.

Millerson despairs of finding a single story of professionalization. "The resounding impression is of individual uniqueness, tempered by an adjustment to the social and educational climate of the time."[16] For some authors, this "individual uniqueness" is in fact directly attributable to "the social and educational climate of the time." One such is Magali Larson.

Larson tells the story of professionalization in a new way. The difference lies in her use of time. For Wilensky, Caplow, and Millerson, professions develop in abstract time. With the exception of the "tempering" just mentioned, this time has no properties of its own that condition the development of professions. In contrast, for Larson such properties are central forces of professionalization. Some professions developed in aristocratic societies, some in democratic ones, still others under corporate capitalism and bureaucracy. The course of professionalization varies in each regime. The larger story determines the time, the conditions, and the structures through which professionalization takes place.[17]

In general form, Larson's stories follow not the convergence plot, but rather a stages-approaching-a-steady-state plot. The steady state is elite status. Larson's central subjects are elites of practitioners, which seek personal rewards through collective mobility. There is no particular content to her generic story of professionalization. Any organizational pattern (association, licensing, etc.) that furthers corporate reward is a logical next step, provided that it is possible within the larger context of the society. Thus the causal links are functional, but their content is determined by the societal context.

Despite Larson's unusual handling of time, however, her story of professionalization still draws on the standard repertory of techniques for telling the story. It is useful to summarize the alternatives available in that repertory. First, stories may assume a central subject of narrative and follow it, or they may chronicle the creation and dissolution of such a subject. Stories proceed by joining a series of specified situ-

ations with links that describe the successive resolution of each situation. These links are usually drawn from a limited set of basic models for why things occur in society—functional, historicist, evolutionary, and so on. Underlying these links is often a single simplifying assumption about why events occur, such as the self-interest model. In putting these links together, social stories take a variety of approaches to the order of events—making it sometimes essential to their outcome, sometimes irrelevant, sometimes partway in between. They also take a variety of approaches to issues of convergence and divergence—some of them recounting the emergence of a steady state like "full professionalization," others the development of oscillation or imbalance. Tellers of social stories also have metaphors for generalizing these stories. Some employ the metaphor of career or life course, searching for a single typical sequence. Others employ more open-ended link-by-link models, using an implicit metaphor of conversation or interaction as their model for sequences.

This somewhat literary analysis allows us to separate the formal from the substantive diversity of professionalization theories. Some of the choices made in analyzing patterns like professionalization we regard as substantive—the choice of an underlying self-interest model, or of functional models for links, or of particular structures (e.g., ethics codes) serving a given function. In past discussions of professionalization, these substantive aspects have sometimes been the focus of attention. But other choices we see as purely formal, like the choice of a central subject and a plot form, and it is important to recognize that many incompatibilities among theories of professionalization arise out of these formal decisions. The "proletarianization of professions" arguments are classic examples. Their central subject is professionals as an occupational class, rather than professions qua social groups. Yet they have been held to reject the concept of professionalization. What they have in fact rejected, or rather qualified, is a certain version of the professionalization argument, the version in which the motive forces of the story are the external rewards professionalization provides to individual professionals. Other versions, with different driving forces, are completely unaffected.[18]

These formal differences in theories of professionalization exacerbate the enduring substantive differences, some of which I noted in outlining the history of studies of professions. It is important to recall those substantive differences here. I earlier distinguished studies of professions in terms of their locus of analysis (individual or society) and the consequences of professionalism they studied (internal or external.) I shall classify substantive views of professionalization slightly dif-

ferently, although again in four basic categories. The four versions can be called the functional, structural, monopolist, and cultural concepts of professionalization. The functional version was the first of these, dominant in the writings of Carr-Saunders and Wilson, Marshall, and Parsons. Profession was here a means to control the asymmetric expert-client relation. Professionalization was simply the evolution of structural guarantees for that control.[19]

In the structuralist writers—three of whom I have just discussed (Millerson, Wilensky, Caplow)—the functions disappeared and the structure alone remained. Profession was merely a form of occupational control; the content of work and the expert-client relation were less important. Professionalization here became an explanation of why the professions displayed such diverse properties; the answer was that some had not finished professionalizing. The explicit focus on structure and its evolution led to theories about the historical forces driving the structure, and hence the structuralists developed the explicit models of professionalization here analyzed.[20]

The monopoly school saw the same structural developments, but attributed them not to a "natural growth," but to a desire for dominance or authority. Professions were corporate groups with "mobility projects" aimed at control of work. For Larson and others, as I have noted, this control was interesting for its influence on the status and power of professions; Freidson was more interested in its effect on such social functions as healing or justice. This school attributed the pattern of professionalization to larger, external social processes—the rise of bureaucracy in Larson, the shift from professionalism to mediation in Johnson. The actual sequence of structures (association, school, etc.) became less important than the sequence of functions they served (identification, exclusion, etc.).[21]

Some recent studies have moved away from the focus on structural regularity that marked prior work on professionalization. Bledstein, Haskell, and others have emphasized the cultural authority of professions, returning to the Parsonian fascination with expertise as a social relation. By making cultural legitimation a central process in professionalization, these writers have set a new criterion for the "professionality" of occupations, replacing the old one of organizational similarity to law and medicine. As I noted before, Bledstein has connected this cultural authority directly to individual decisions for mobility.[22]

Given such diversity, both formal and substantive, it may seem hard to consider the validity of professionalization arguments in general. Wilensky's regular sequence of organizations is a far cry from Bledstein's rise of a "metaphor and means" for vertical mobility. But it is

essential that we do consider whether the general professionalization argument can be successfully defended. The various views can in fact be synthesized into a general concept of professionalization, as follows:

> Expert, white-collar occupations evolve towards a particular structural and cultural form of occupational control. The structural form is called profession and consists of a series of organizations for association, for control, and for work. (In its strong form, the professionalization concept argues that these organizations develop in a certain order.) Culturally, professions legitimate their control by attaching their expertise to values with general cultural legitimacy, increasingly the values of rationality, efficiency, and science.

This synthetic professionalization concept has some powerful successes to its credit. As sociological concepts go, it is relatively coherent and its terms relatively well-defined. In the strong (structural) form especially, the organizations and their sequence were particularly easy to measure and surprisingly comparable from case to case. The concept's focus on expertise referred directly to general theories of occupational control. Moreover, not only was professionalization well behaved theoretically and operationally, it also had no small empirical power. The major British and American professions seemed to follow it relatively well, although organization-based professions like the military and the clergy created some problems. As I noted, Wilensky tested the strong form on a sizable sample of American groups and found great regularity in the sequence of organizations.

At the same time, the professionalization concept has had some grave difficulties. First, it turns out that the results of Wilensky's strong form test were largely artifactual. Second, more than a decade of historical case studies shows that most of its underlying assumptions are false.

To test Wilensky's argument, I have studied the order of eight events in 130 American and British professions. My analysis splits occupations studied into three groups: recognized free professions (about 20 each in both America and Britain), subordinate professions (again about 20 in each case), and an "other" group containing various pseudo and would-be professions. The events ordered were:

1. First (national) professional association
2. First governmentally sponsored licensing legislation
3. First professional examinations
4. First professional school separate from some other profession
5. First university-based professional education
6. First ethics code
7. First national-level journal

8. First accreditation of schools (U.S.) or certification by association (England)

The data were gathered from a wide variety of sources and were, of course, incomplete in many cases. (Missing data does not, however, bias the results, given the methods used.) The analysis proceeded by finding mean "distances" between the events under a variety of metrics (e.g., real time, log time) and then using these distances to establish an "order of professionalization." I applied a simple one-dimensional scaling algorithm to find that order. The results were that there is possibly a regular order among the American free and subordinate professions, but none among the American other category or among any of the three British categories.[23]

Perhaps more importantly, analysis of the assumptions of this formalization of Wilensky's approach shows that the results cannot help but be artifactual. Since there is one major, national professional association but, in many professions, dozens of schools, it is inevitable by probability theory alone that the first school will precede the association. Similarly, Wilensky found university education to follow separate schooling not because it necessarily did, but because he included university schooling as a subset of separate education generally. Thus, the date of the first separate school was either that of the first university school or that of the first nonuniversity school, should one exist. It was therefore inevitable that the "separate school" event should appear, generally, before the university school event. There is in fact no real empirical support for the strong form hypothesis that the organizations seen in professionalization arrive in a particular sequence.[24]

The empirical problems of the strong form hypothesis of professionalization would not be so important were it not for the evidence accumulating against the underlying assumptions of the concept itself. There are five basic assumptions hidden in my synthetic concept of professionalization. The first is that change is unidirectional; professions evolve towards a given form, structurally and culturally. Second, the evolution of individual professions does not explicitly depend on that of others; professionalization can be treated case by case. Third, the social structure and cultural claims of professions are more important than the work professions do; the latter is unmentioned in theoretical studies of professionalization, although it makes obligatory appearances in case studies. Fourth, professions are homogeneous units; what internal differentiation they possess reflects contingencies of the "professionalization project." Fifth, professionalization as a process does not change with time; although a description of history, it lacks a history of its own. Of course particular writers have avoided various of

these assumptions. Nonetheless, this summary captures the concept as it is generally used.

The assumption of unidirectionality has been attacked by both sociological theorists and historians. The theorists have come up with deprofessionalization and proletarianization to refer to the apparent decrease in professional legitimacy and autonomy on the one hand and to the lessening benefits of professionalism for the members of the professions on the other. The historians have studied numerous professional or pseudoprofessional groups that have stalled or even died on the high road of professionalization—psychological mediums, electrotherapists and railway surgeons, computer "coders," midwives. They have studied amalgamation, among British nineteenth-century doctors and among twentieth-century social workers, and also division, among twentieth century British doctors and among social and religious workers in America. In short, there are clearly a variety of directions for development, and development towards strong control is but one of them.[25]

The assumption that one profession's development is independent of another's is threatened implicitly but no less strongly. It is true that most work on professions continues to be done on a profession-by-profession basis. But evidence available in this very work questions such a procedure strongly. Much work on subprofessions in the medical area emphasizes the interdependence of professional development, as do the cases of American psychiatry and social work, of the various types of engineers, of law and accounting. Books on individual professions spend much of their time on interprofessional relations, but none draws the obvious moral that interprofessional relations are potentially the central feature of professional development.[26]

The assumption that structure is more important than actual work is, like unidirectionality, an aspect of the sociological theory challenged by historical work. Sociological work on professions, including much of the power literature of the last decade, pays little attention to the actual work that is done and the expertise used to do it. Freidson's work is a striking exception. Historical study, by contrast, has emphasized the actual work performed. In professions as diverse as librarianship, engineering, psychiatry, and the clergy, historians have shown the intimate relation of professional structure and culture to work itself. The sociological theorists have not learned from this that work must be the focus of a concept of professional development.[27]

Ignoring internal differentiation in professions has helped the professionalization concept simplify what it has to explain. But recent work implies that this assumption, too, is dangerous. Sociologists

themselves have contributed analyses of differences in intraprofessional prestige, in locations of work, in access to professional power. While sociologists have not in general connected these internal patterns to patterns of professional development, historians have done so, in studies of the legal profession, of engineering, of medicine. The development of internal differences is bound directly to the development of professionalism.[28]

Finally, the assumption that professionalization is a general process without any history of its own has been challenged forcefully by the sociological theorists themselves, particularly Johnson and Larson. Both noted that the increasing involvement of the state reshaped professionalization, as did the general drift towards bureaucratic practice. These lessons were regarded as long overdue by both the historians and the sociologists studying Continental professions, for the changes described by Larson and Johnson brought the unusual professions of England and America more in line with the model of professionalism long dominant in France and Germany.[29]

On balance, then, the evidence argues for a new approach to professional development to replace the general professionalization concept. There is, of course, great diversity in professionalization theories. Much of it, as I have argued, is formal diversity. There are many theories claiming to be general theories about professional development that are in fact special theories of this or that aspect of it, and even the general theories often pose their analyses in fundamentally different narrative terms. And there are wide differences in the substance of these general theories—in the driving mechanisms they posit, in the pattern of causation they adopt, in the particular structures they emphasize. Yet most professionalization theories follow a common approach to their subject, what I called the synthetic theory. This synthetic theory, despite the strong support that many case studies give it, has profound shortcomings. A serious empirical test rejects it. More importantly, its basic assumptions have all been overthrown by recent empirical work. These problems imply that the case study support is more illusory than real.

In the chapters that follow I will propose an alternative theory that reverses the problematic assumptions of professionalization theories. The alternative assumptions begin with a focus on work. The central problem with the current concept of professionalization is its focus on structure rather than work. It is the content of the professions' work that the case studies tell us is changing. It is control of work that brings the professions into conflict with each other and makes their histories interdependent. It is differentiation in types of work that often leads

to serious differentiation within the professions. By switching from a focus on the organizational structures of professions to a focus on groups with common work we replace several of the problematic assumptions at once.

The central phenomenon of professional life is thus the link between a profession and its work, a link I shall call jurisdiction. To analyze professional development is to analyze how this link is created in work, how it is anchored by formal and informal social structure, and how the interplay of jurisdictional links between professions determines the history of the individual professions themselves.

Cases of Professional Development

To illustrate the complexities that any theory of professional development must handle, I shall give in the remainder of this chapter some examples of that process. These examples represent the much larger collection of case studies that I am trying to explain. Such exemplary vignettes embody a compromise between several ways of approaching the data. A positivist would reduce all these histories to coded facts and present them as dependent variables. A theorist would present an exemplary case at length and delineate the mechanisms at play within it. I wish to balance these contrary imperatives. On the one hand, the diversity of the professions warrants a narrative presentation of contrasting cases. On the other, we must abstract from such cases and generate testable ideas. My compromise is to illustrate the problems of explanation with these brief pictures.[30]

Let us begin with the familiar case of American medicine.[31] Like many American professions, medicine had two waves of professionalizing activity. The first, which began a little before the Revolution, saw the founding of a few early schools, the passage of some exclusive state licensing laws, and the creation and empowerment of some local and state societies. The Jacksonian era struck down this exclusivism and opened the gates of competition. A variety of sectarian and folk healers appeared. Among these were the homeopaths, who espoused, among other novel ideas, the practice of not killing patients with treatment. This practice, and the good results that attended it, made the homeopaths rather dangerous adversaries to "regular medicine." There ensued an intense war over who had the right to cure people. Each side claimed the legitimacy of science, debated the safety of the public, and attacked its opponents in editorials and speeches. The regulars devised exclusionary ethics rules requiring a dying patient to dismiss an attending irregular as a condition of their own attention. In this, its

darkest hour, regular medicine at last saw fit to found its national association. By the late nineteenth century, the regulars were fortified by the new scientific medicine from Europe. Although concerned with diagnosis, etiology, and pathology more than with treatment, European medicine claimed a few spectacular therapeutic successes that underscored its abstract power. Thus reinforced, the regulars started a national journal, revised their ethics, and began to reform their schools. From the homeopaths they had learned to avoid heroic treatment, and the two groups united around the turn of the century to fight off new outside threats—the osteopaths and later the chiropractors. In a whirlwind of reform from above, the nebulous world of proprietary medical schools, patent medicine, and unregulated practice vanished under the clear organization radiating from a powerful, nationally united profession. The community general hospital, the foundation organization of modern medicine, developed rapidly. Although generally fearful of state intervention, American medicine profited immensely from the formation of public and private insurance schemes, which guaranteed its income and professional dominance. By midcentury it had assumed a position of social prominence and power envied throughout the occupational world. Included in its vast organizational empire were a host of subordinate professional groups.

The case of American medicine shows how complicated and interwoven are the questions about what professions do and how they interrelate. If one aims to "find the origins of" American medicine, then the homeopaths are an outside force that enters the picture, fights with the protagonist, and then unites with it. But such an interpretation ignores the virtual dissolution of regular medicine under the Jacksonian onslaught. The "doing of healing" became a free-for-all. The protagonist itself is not a continuous entity. Development, activity, and interprofessional relations are bound up together.

The medical profession's absolute control of bodily ills required defensive work on a number of borders. Perhaps the most important of these borders was the hazy one between bodily and mental ailments. Here emerged a second professional group, organizationally a part of medicine but intellectually and practically separate from it. This second sketch, of American psychiatry, shows again how complex and intertwined is the web of professional development. (I will give a sustained analysis of this case in chapter 10.)[32]

Psychiatry began when a group of enterprising medical reformers argued in the early nineteenth century that madmen ought to be removed from the jurisdiction of the legal authorities and placed under that of the medical profession. Madmen are sick, they said; give them

to us and we will cure them. A new theory and therapy justified the shift, and private bodies and state legislatures were soon dotting the countryside with insane asylums. Psychiatry was the profession of the superintendents of these institutions. (Nonsuperintendents were finally admitted to the organized profession in the 1880s.) Like teaching and social work, and unlike its parent, medicine, psychiatry thus arose out of an organizational form—the hospital for the insane. An association, journal, and official principles sprang simultaneously into being in the mid-1840s, about the same time as the AMA was founded. Throughout the latter half of the century, psychiatry was an elite profession, its members exceeding most of their medical brethren in income, power, and prestige. But the latter half of the century also brought decline. The early hopes of cure proved illusory; the psychiatrists gradually became administrators of custodial warehouses.

Meanwhile, the jurisdiction that would ultimately become psychiatry's was being explored by other pioneers, the neurologists. From their bloody baptism in the field hospitals of the Civil War, these men emerged to become general consulting specialists, helping their medical colleagues with perplexing cases. They took from other physicians any patient whose otherwise untreatable illness could somehow be related to "nerves." Under this conveniently vague heading, they collected the misfits whose recalcitrant illnesses impugned the new efficacy of medicine. Heavily influenced by German medicine, they were skeptical of treatment in general, and when cures were discovered, as for the "nervous" endocrine diseases, they at once returned the diseases to general medical jurisdiction. The neurologists developed their association, journals, and university teaching positions during the second wave of medical professionalization.

But they soon found themselves overwhelmed by the horde of "nervous" patients other physicians referred to them. These patients had few but perplexing organic symptoms; for the most part the problem seemed to be "in their minds." As a result, neurologists and psychiatrists began to handle this jurisdiction together, the neurologists defining the patients by their lack of response to standard treatment, the psychiatrists seeing them as incipiently insane. For about twenty years after the turn of the century the two groups interpenetrated. Then in a sudden shift, they divided. The term "neurologist" came to refer to organic physicians generally working in hospitals. Psychiatrists took over the neurologists' old position as the outpatient border guards of the medical profession, handling the symptoms and diseases that seemed not quite real. At the same time, they began to accept direct referrals from the lay community.

The direct referrals reflected the psychiatrists' rapid, entreprenuerial expansion into areas of social control long dominated by other professions. With the help of a popular front organization, the National Committee on Mental Hygiene, psychiatrists in the twenties tried to seize control over juvenile delinquency, alcoholism, industrial unrest, marital strife, and numerous other areas. This brought them into violent competition with the clergy and the law among the older professions, and psychology and social work among the newer ones. Intellectually, the psychiatrists routed all but the law, although their numbers were too small to take more than a supervisory role in the jurisdictions they seized. The profession continued uncontested until the sudden expansion of demand for psychotherapy in the 1970s found it so understaffed that psychology and social work penetrated the third party payment schemes that had so long protected its monopoly.

The story of psychiatry is thus a different one from that of medicine generally. The profession began with an organization. It rushed through the formalities of professionalization—association, journal, code—in a decade. It changed jurisdiction almost completely over its 150-year history. Again we see that the central questions of how professions develop are tied up with questions of interprofessional relations and the content of professional activity. Professionalization occurs, to be sure, but in a context that helps determine its course. A comprehensive theory of professional life must deal with these complex facts of jurisdictional competition and interprofessional relations. This can be seen even more clearly in the British professions.

Unlike American professions of the late eighteenth century, their contemporaries in England were not dominated by a metropolis distant in space, but by traditions distant in time. Law in particular could trace its origins to the personal councils of the first Plantagenets.[33] The schools and associations of the Bar, the Inns of Court, had lost their records so long before that no one knew how old they were. Even less was known about the Inns of Chancery, in which were collected many members of the lower branches of the profession, the ancestors of the present solicitors. The profession had an intricate hierarchy, as befitted its semiofficial origins, but can be loosely understood as having three levels in each of a number of jurisdictions. The three levels were distinguished by function, the highest being that of judging, the next that of oral argument, the third that of representing or appearing for a litigant. Each court had its own jurisdiction and its own names for these levels—serjeants, barristers, and solicitors in common law; chancellor, barristers, and attorneys in equity; judges, doctors, and proctors in the civil law courts of Admiralty and Arches. (The last was

the chief ecclesiastical court, which until the 1870s had jurisdiction over all family matters other than property.)

The common law and equity professions of the late eighteenth century were in some senses more appearance than reality. The Inns of Court, which had at times been vibrant, active organizations, were at low ebb. Education was moribund; barristers and others learned their work on the job. Discipline was exercised, very occasionally, by the courts and the administrative committees of the Inns, the Benchers. Despite this apparent indolence, the common lawyers of this period had just won a signal professional victory over the better-educated and more formally professional doctors of civil law. Under the leadership of Mansfield and the other great common law judges, they had over the preceding two centuries stolen the entire commercial jurisdiction from the Admiralty courts and made it part of common law.

The security of the barristers was upset by a revolution from below. The attorneys and solicitors built in the early nineteenthth century a national association (really a metropolitan one, for most legal business was done in London), which undertook what we would now call serious professionalization. It mandated a formal apprenticeship, prepared a careful list of authorized practitioners, imposed professional examinations, and began a serious and careful professional discipline. It also fought for, and won, a monopoly of the newly lucrative business of conveyancing (property transfer). The barristers responded by consolidating their own absolute monopoly of verbal pleading, which had been granted several centuries before over the intense objections of the lower branches. They removed their last competitors, the moribund serjeants, consolidated the jurisdictions of their courts, and reaffirmed the old rule that all judges be barristers. As for professionalization in the modern sense, they did less than nothing. By the mid-twentieth century there was still no single list of authorized barristers, no national association, no central disciplinary body. The educational activities of the Inns continued nonexistent. Although the English universities now gave bachelor's degrees in common law, passing the bar was still a matter of sitting terms at the Inns and enduring a vague apprenticeship. Unlike the physicians, their counterparts in the British nineteenth-century medical hierarchy, the barristers never made peace with or absorbed their competitors from below.[34]

The solicitors, as the more adventurous branch of the profession, faced numerous challenges after their formal professionalization. They early began to give general business and financial advice. Since their services were generally required for formal business activity, this area was a natural zone of expansion. The expansion had a number of inter-

esting effects. First, the slow growth imposed on the profession by its own strict standards meant that it was overwhelmed by the welter of commercial and real estate work that was generated by business expansion. In consequence, its chief jurisdictional monopoly, conveyancing, had by this century been delegated to a subordinate professional group, the managing clerks, who did the work under the very loose supervision of solicitors. This internal subordination of routine work is a characteristic strategy of professions claiming more jurisdiction than they can effectively serve, American medicine being the best example.

From the outside, however, solicitors faced competition from a new profession focused directly on money itself. Emerging in the early nineteenth century, this new group, the accountants, began in Scotland as a branch of the legal profession, and in England as an outgrowth of laws requiring formal audits of the new joint-stock companies.[35] Sorting out the financial tangles of bankruptcy and liquidation was in fact the chief activity of accountants in those early days of entrepreneurial individualism. As commercial affairs became more regular and bankruptcies less frequent, accountants in England moved to monopolize the business of auditing. Unlike their later American counterparts, they did relatively little in the area of cost accounting—working within firms to tell managers how, why, and whether they were actually making money. In the area of financial advice and corporate restructuring, accountants and solicitors reached an uneasy truce. Each had its own home turf; this area between was often one of conflict.

The accountants developed national and local organizations simultaneously around 1880. Their journal dates from the same period, as do their strict disciplinary practices and their examinations for entrance. Accounting education was supervised and regulated by the national society, although it took place in the characteristically British setting of articled clerkship with a member of the profession. Like the solicitors, the chartered accountants in fact had far more business than their slow growth could handle, and soon were forced to tolerate at least one group of less educated and certified competitors, the Incorporated Accountants. (The continued exclusivism of the Chartered and Incorporated Accountants means that many other groups of accountants are organized outside these leaders of the profession.) In the present century, the profession underwent a further change, in this case a divergent one. Accounting firms continued to depend on corporate auditing work. But the conglomeration of industries led to the replacement of local with conglomerate accountants. There resulted a rapid division of the accounting world into a very few giant, transnational firms, auditing transnational commercial organizations, and a large

number of individuals and small partnerships doing a completely different local business.

The case of English accounting provides a particularly good example of how professionalization in the narrow sense of acquiring an association, education, licensure, and even state-sanctioned monopoly is merely the outward form of successful professional life. The accountants profited from the earlier examples of the solicitors, apothecaries, and surgeons, and created all the proper attributes of professionalism in short order. What really determined the history of the profession was the development and shift of its jurisdiction—from bankruptcy to auditing, with gradual expansion into cost accounting and now into "management services." Here, too, we see a number of other characteristic developments of professional life—the competition from below, the gradual molding of profession to clientele, the maintenance of a strategic heartland monopoly. Yet at the same time accounting showed its willingness for head-on competition—with law over the definition of profit, with law and banking over the jurisdiction of business advice, with management over the provision of staff services. There is much more here than is told by the simple image of professionalization.

But even more troubling questions about the way professions develop and interrelate arise when one leaves the familiar Anglo-American success stories and studies either the continental professions with their civil-servant character or the failed professions that litter our own history.

In France, the new effects arise because professional life is overshadowed by the state. While independent competition still takes place, and independent professional evolution occurs, both aim immediately at the achievement of certain status with the state. The absolute, centralized, and rationalized character of French government led it to take a decisive role in organizing occupations both before and after the Revolution. As a result, developed professions all tend to look alike in structure. At the same time, protoprofessions tend to be ignored altogether; things unrecognized by the state seem unimportant.

Thus, the French legal profession, while in some ways reminiscent of the English one, differs from it in essential ways.[36] In the first place, it is broken up into a different set of jurisdictions, with different relations between them. (I am here presenting the profession in its pre-1972 form. The fusion of that year merged *avocats* and *avoués* and created a new group of *conseils juridiques* out of the old *agréés*.) *Avocats*, tracing their roots well back into medieval times, are roughly analogous to barristers. They are organized into bars under each different court, and their tacit monopoly of oral pleading in many courts

was made formal in the Napoleonic Code. But they are unlike the English Bar in many ways. They share their self-disciplinary function with the courts, as the British have not since the Middle Ages. Indeed, the French courts have on occasion reorganized their bars completely. The Bar was abolished altogether during the early years of the Revolution and was reinstated with some reluctance by Napoleon, who detested lawyers. The *avocats* are also unlike the barristers in their requirement of university legal education and formal attendance at court, requirements for admission to the bar dating from before the sixteenth century. Under the Old Regime they seldom if ever became judges in higher courts, and in the modern French profession the *magistrats* are a separate group with separate educational requirements. This is precisely the opposite of the British situation, where barristers monopolize the bench in the higher courts.

Beyond the *avocats*, the French legal profession looked in 1970 as if it had no history. Its major branches all had the same structure and traced that structure to the lucid clarity of laws governing public officials. The various branches were separated by jurisdiction. The *avoués* appeared for their clients; they filed forms and motions and shepherded the cases through the court. The *notaires* recorded formal documents and conducted the transactions so recorded, thus controlling marriage, property transfer, probate, and other jurisdictions controlled by attorneys in England and lawyers in America. *Huissiers* served official papers and levied executions, both for courts and for private parties, combining what in America would be the functions of process servers, bailiffs, and collection agents. *Greffiers* kept court records and other official documents, particularly those pertaining to businesses. All of these jurisdictions were formalized in legislation or decree. So also was the professional structure. Each group (or *ordre*) was organized into local (*départementale*), regional, and national *chambres*. These bodies were officially charged by the state with keeping records and rolls, with originating disciplinary action and administering court regulations, with running the welfare systems for the *ordre*, and with governing conditions for subordinate workers. The Code also set educational requirements for the various orders. Perhaps the most astonishing aspect of the regulations of these professional groups, to the Anglo-American observer, is their formal provision for the purchase of office. Each member of these groups of *officiers ministériels* bought his position when he entered the profession and sold it (or bequeathed it) when he left it. The price was normally from four to ten times the annual income. The state thus had indirect control over the number of these officials, as well as over their behavior.

Two things happened as the legal profession evolved within this set structure. First, de facto changes reshaped the official structure. While *notaires* are not required to have law degrees, most in fact do. *Avoués* typically have the second (*licencié*), not the first (*capacité*), degree in law, as they are required. Second, informal groups have emerged serving new jurisdictions unforeseen in Napoleonic times. These have been regulated extemporaneously by the courts involved during the prolonged period in which practitioners agitated for state recognition. When state recognition came, these new groups became, overnight, indistinguishable in structure from the other branches. Among the groups emerging in this way were the *agréés*, a group of *avocats*, *notaires*, and *hommes d'affaires* who began to represent parties in the commercial courts in the mid-nineteenth century. They were accepted (hence the name *agréé*) and listed officially by those courts. Having arisen out of an open professional competition, they were formally regulated in 1941, acquiring an examination, court-shared discipline, purchased offices, and national, regional, and local governing bodies, like the other branches. Similar groups are the *commissaires-priseurs*, who monopolize judicially ordered appraisal and auction, the as-yet unregulated *arbitres-rapporteurs*, who examine accounts and attempt conciliation in commercial cases, and the *syndics administrateurs judiciaires et liquidateurs judiciaires*, who handle bankruptcy and receivership (regulated in 1955). In most cases, one individual can hold only one of these titles, although *avoués* and others may be enrolled as *syndics*. All of these groups possess voluntary associations that long antedate the state *chambres* that presently govern them, associations that indeed did the lobbying that brought state regulation about. With the coming of that regulation, however, the voluntary groups seem somewhat eclipsed.

The legal profession in France thus presents a different version of professional development and interrelations from what we have seen so far. Development here means development toward official status. Interprofessional relations means regulated jurisdiction. Yet before regulation and in the informal realities after it, professional development continues in hidden ways. These ways are channeled and influenced by state structures, but are in some ways independent of them. An effective theory of professional development must therefore be general enough to deal with the fact of intense state participation in professionalization.

It must also be wide enough to embrace the phenomenon of professional death. We are so fascinated with the success of American medicine, in particular, that we forget the specialized, knowledge-

based occupations that have disappeared. Some have gone because the organization or technology that created them has disappeared. The railroad professions and protoprofessions—dispatchers, agents, surgeons—are one such example. Had they developed knowledge that abstracted beyond the world of the railroad, they might have survived its fall. But dispatching did not become what we now think of as operations research, even though its central task was essentially under the jurisdiction now held by that profession. Because they lacked abstraction, dispatchers died with their technology. Another such group are the itinerant entertainers—musicians, dancing masters, singing teachers—whose numbers have been decimated by the centralization of entertainment through the mass media. (Local entertainment resurfaced, of course, but only through finding a foundation in the profession of public school teaching.)[37]

A good case of professional death is that of the psychological mediums. Mediums flourished in the latter nineteenth century as the professional embodiment of spiritualism. After the turn of the century, spiritualism, insofar as it survived at all, became an organized church of the afterlife, complete with congregations and ministers. But for fifty years its banner was carried by a group of mediums several hundred strong.

The medium's skill was her ability to encourage, through passivity and openness, effective communication between her audience and the inhabitants of the spiritual world. The first followers of the calling began in the 1850s, although Mesmerism, Swedenborgianism, and a variety of other predecessors had prepared the way. The weekly journal of the mediums, *Banner of Light*, appeared from 1857 to 1907. The Mediums Mutual Aid Society, aiming at instruction and support of all using mediumistic powers, was founded in 1860. A variety of client and support groups such as the National Organization of Spiritualists flourished briefly and discussed, in vain, the problem of regulating the charlatans. An official school of mediumship was founded by Morris Pratt at Whitewater, Wisconsin.

It is important to realize that mediumship fits the basic definition of a profession very well. It applied a set of esoteric skills to particular cases. Certainly it possessed all the organizational paraphernalia of a profession—school, association, attempted regulation. It is important, too, to recall that many well-known Americans patronized mediums and that spiritualism was perceived as a kind of "scientized" religion. As R. L. Moore has pointed out, mediums enabled people to undertake major decisions without impugning existing states of social affairs or assuming full personal responsibility. It was a jurisdiction that psy-

chiatry was later to stumble into, and indeed a number of psychiatry's early battles were fought with mediums and their descendants the spiritualist healers.[38]

In reflecting about the development of professions, then, we must develop answers that tell us why mediumship grew the way it did and why it died so quickly. The answers that spring to mind are not very helpful. It is useless saying spiritualism was a ridiculous waste of time since the mediums simply couldn't deliver results. Neither could nineteenth century medicine. Nor is it helpful to identify "external" factors —the rise of science, the liberalizing of Protestantism, the recognition of the psyche. For these are all intimately tied to other competing professions—the clergy, the psychiatrists and neurologists, the academic psychologists who took over psychic research. So that even while a model of professional development must take account of such external factors, it must also see their direct embodiment in interprofessional relations.

These brief examples show some of the breathtaking diversity of professional life. It has been easy to mistake American medicine for the paradigm. In reality the professions are a diverse lot—winners and losers, public officials and private individuals, autocrats and subordinates. Many a profession has gone from rags to riches, not a few the other way. Many claimants have never found a niche in the system at all. Yet all these are a part of professional life. Beyond this diversity, these examples show how the development of the formal attributes of a profession is bound up with the pursuit of jurisdiction and the besting of rival professions. The organizational formalities of professions are meaningless unless we understand their context. This context always relates back to the power of the professions' knowledge systems, their abstracting ability to define old problems in new ways. Abstraction enables survival. It is with abstraction that law and accounting fought frontally over tax advice, the one because it writes the laws, the other because it defines what the prescribed numbers mean. It is with abstractions that psychiatry stole the neurotics from neurology, the abstractions of its fancy new Freudianism. It is with abstraction that American medicine claims all of deviance, the abstraction of its all-powerful disease metaphor.[39]

Finally, these vignettes have introduced some of my cast of characters. Much of the book involves theoretical statements that make it easy to forget the historical events they abstract. To me these events, case by case, profession by profession, are the test of the enterprise.

One cannot build an argument that works in every case. But one must build an argument that works for most. Case studies of professions are both the raw material of the theory and the audience that says thumbs up or down. It is important that the reader begin to make their acquaintance.